



Graffiti in Vienna's Residential Areas (A Snapshot)

Anita Pal / ap224pu@student.lnu.se

Submission Date: 27-02-2026

Word Count: 2,046 words.

<https://viennagraffiti.omeka.net>

CONTEXTUALISING THE PROJECT

This project documents graffiti in Vienna's 21st and 22nd districts, focusing on markings found in residential neighbourhoods rather than in well-known street-art zones. The decision to digitise graffiti emerged from an interest in the everyday cultural landscape—those visual traces that shape how residents experience their surroundings but are rarely preserved, studied, or even noticed. The collection consists of a small but diverse set of graffiti works photographed in the 21st and 22nd districts, chosen to represent the everyday, anonymous markings that shape the city's social texture. By photographing and cataloguing these works, the project aims to foreground the cultural meaning embedded in ordinary spaces.

Similar documentation efforts exist, such as the *Vienna Street Art Guide* published by Wien Tourismus and several Instagram-based graffiti archives (e.g., @viennastreetart). However, these typically focus on legal walls or curated murals rather than the everyday markings found in residential districts.

The choice of the 21st and 22nd districts was both pragmatic and conceptual. These areas are geographically accessible and contain a mix of housing estates, suburban streets, and transit corridors where graffiti appears in diverse forms: tags on bins, stickers on utility boxes, throw-ups on underpasses, and occasional murals. Their relative distance from Vienna's tourist-oriented centre also means that the graffiti here is less curated and more reflective of local expression.

This project treats graffiti as a form of immovable cultural heritage—tangible, site-specific, and vulnerable to erasure. This conceptual framing draws on Watkins and Beaver's (2008, pp. 13–15) distinction between tangible and immovable heritage, as well as UNESCO's (2003, p. 1) emphasis on preserving cultural materials at risk of disappearance. Graffiti's ephemerality, susceptibility to removal, and dependence on urban context make it a compelling subject for digitisation.

WORKFLOW

Planning and Fieldwork

The project began with exploratory walks through the two districts to assess feasibility and identify the types of graffiti present. Conducting these walks at different times of day—noon, afternoon, and late evening—helped determine when the streets were quiet enough to photograph without obstruction. This stage revealed how residential environments complicate digitisation, since graffiti often appears on surfaces that may include private property or identifiable individuals, forcing constant ethical and practical negotiation. Nightfall ultimately proved the most practical time for photography, though it introduced complications such as low light and colour distortion.

Terras (2018, pp. 47–49) emphasises that digitisation requires balancing ideal standards with real-world constraints. This principle guided the decision to use a mobile phone camera rather than professional equipment. While a DSLR would have produced higher-quality images, the project's scope, timeframe, and budget made mobile photography the most realistic option. The trade-off was increased noise and reduced dynamic range, which required careful editing later.

Capturing and Preparing Data

Photographs were taken systematically, with each graffiti work captured from multiple angles to ensure at least one usable image. The surrounding environment—walls, bins, bus stops, fences—was intentionally included, reflecting the understanding that graffiti's meaning is inseparable from its location. This aligns with Pearce's (1992, pp. 15–22) argument that cultural objects must be understood within their contextual relationships.

Once captured, images were uploaded to a dedicated Google Drive folder. Establishing a consistent file-naming convention early on (e.g., graffiti_green_bin_21st) proved essential for later cataloguing. This step reflects Miller's (2022, pp. 29–30) emphasis on metadata consistency as a foundation for digital collection management.

Editing and File Formats

Images were minimally edited in Photopea, primarily by cropping and adjusting brightness. Drucker's (2021, pp. 43–45) discussion of lossy versus lossless formats informed the decision to retain JPEGs rather than convert them to TIFFs. While TIFFs offer superior preservation quality, the project's scale and Omeka's storage limitations made JPEGs the more practical choice. This decision illustrates Drucker's (2021, pp. 45–47) point that digitisation always involves a compromise between ideal preservation standards and available resources.

Uploading and Describing Items

Once edited, images were uploaded to Omeka and described using a hybrid metadata model combining Dublin Core with additional fields inspired by CDWA and VRA Core. This step demonstrated Gilliland's (2016) point that metadata creation is inherently interpretive, requiring iterative decisions about what information is meaningful to represent (pp. 1–20). Early attempts at description confirmed that Dublin Core's generality limits its ability to capture the material and spatial specificity required for documenting immovable urban heritage (Dublin Core Metadata Initiative, 2024). For example, the distinction between the location of creation (where the graffiti physically exists) and the location of documentation (where the photograph was taken) is crucial for immovable heritage but not explicitly supported in unqualified Dublin Core.

A significant challenge was determining how to describe authorship. Graffiti artists are often anonymous, and identifying them could raise ethical concerns, especially when works are unsanctioned. Following Watkins and Beaver's (2008, pp. 9–12) discussion of heritage ethics, the project opted to list the creator as "Unknown" and focus instead on the photographer's role.

Challenges and Resolutions

Several challenges emerged during the workflow:

- Managing low-light conditions without distorting colours.
- Avoiding identifiable individuals in residential areas.
- Addressing ethical concerns around documenting illegal activity.

These challenges reinforced the idea that digitisation is not a neutral process but an interpretive one, shaped by practical, ethical, and conceptual decisions.

DESCRIBING DESCRIPTIONS

Metadata determines how digital objects are discovered, interpreted, and reused. Dublin Core's flexibility makes it suitable for Omeka, but its generality can obscure important distinctions for site-specific cultural heritage. Gilliland (2016, pp. 1–20) argues that metadata must capture content, structure, and context; for graffiti, context is especially significant.

To address this, the project incorporated additional fields inspired by CDWA and VRA Core, including:

- **material** (e.g., spray paint, marker)
- **technique** (e.g., tagging, stencil)
- **location.site** (e.g., bin, wall, utility box)
- **location.creation** (street name or coordinates)
- **location.documentation** (photographer's vantage point)

These fields enhance discovery by enabling users to search for graffiti by type, surface, or location. They also support reusability by providing structured, interoperable data that could be integrated into larger visual-culture databases. At the same time, the project had to make compromises. While GPS coordinates would offer precise spatial metadata, collecting them for every item would have significantly slowed fieldwork. Instead, street-level descriptions were used, balancing precision with feasibility.

Rights metadata also required careful consideration. While the photographs are the researcher's own, the graffiti itself is created by anonymous individuals, often illegally. Thus, the rights field clarifies that the photographer owns the copyright to the digital images, while the depicted works remain the intellectual property of their unknown creators.

ANALYSIS

The digitisation process is closely aligned with several concepts discussed in the course. First, the project demonstrated Terras's (2018, pp. 48–49) argument that digitisation is labour-intensive and shaped by material constraints. Decisions about equipment, file formats, and editing were influenced more by practical limitations than by ideal standards. Additionally, the project illustrated Drucker's (2021, pp. 45–47) argument that digital objects are inherently unstable and require ongoing maintenance. The choice of JPEGs, while pragmatic, raises long-term preservation concerns that would need to be addressed in an institutional context. The project also parallels the Smithsonian's digitisation initiatives, where decisions about metadata granularity and contextual photography significantly shape how users interpret cultural materials.

Choosing which fields to include—and which to omit—shaped how the graffiti is represented and understood. The decision to treat graffiti as immovable heritage also reflects Watkins and Beaver's (2008, pp. 13–15) argument that heritage is socially constructed rather than inherent. Finally, the project echoed discussions about authenticity and context. Digitising graffiti preserves its visual form but inevitably alters its meaning by removing it from its physical environment. Including contextual photographs mitigates this loss but cannot fully replicate the embodied experience of encountering graffiti in reality.

EXTRAPOLATIONS

If expanded into a city-wide or institutional initiative, the project would require significant logistical, ethical, and infrastructural planning.

Institutional Partnerships

Potential partners include:

- Wien Museum.
- MA 7 (Cultural Affairs).
- Local street-art organisations.

These partnerships could support funding, outreach, and long-term preservation.

Ethical Considerations

Scaling up would intensify ethical challenges:

- Documenting illegal graffiti risks exposing artists.
- Photographing residential areas raises privacy concerns.
- Community engagement would be essential to avoid misrepresentation.

An institutional project would need clear ethical guidelines, anonymisation protocols, and community advisory boards.

Preservation and Sustainability

- Migration to preservation-grade formats (TIFF).
- Redundant storage and integrity checks.
- Stable hosting infrastructure.

Long-term sustainability would require adopting institutional workflows—such as TIFF masters, redundant storage, and integrity checks—that mirror professional digitisation infrastructures (Drucker, 2021, pp. 45–47).

Audience and Outreach

A larger project could serve:

- Researchers studying urban culture.
- Residents.
- Artists and cultural practitioners.
- Educators.

Promotion could involve exhibitions, public talks, or interactive maps.

CONCLUSION

This project demonstrates how digitising everyday graffiti can reveal overlooked aspects of Vienna’s cultural landscape. Through fieldwork, photography, metadata creation, and reflection, the project engaged with the full digitisation workflow and the conceptual issues surrounding cultural heritage. While small in scale, it highlights the interpretive labour involved in digitisation and the potential for expansion into a meaningful institutional initiative. It also highlights the cultural value of documenting everyday, often overlooked forms of urban expression.

APPENDIX

Catalogue

The catalogue for this project is available on GitHub as both an [Excel file](#) and a [PDF](#).

Metadata Explanation

The catalogue for this project was developed using a metadata structure grounded in the Dublin Core Metadata Element Set, the schema that underpins Omeka and provides a flexible, widely interoperable framework for describing digital cultural heritage objects (Dublin Core Metadata Initiative, 2024; Miller, 2022). While Dublin Core offers broad applicability, its generality can limit the descriptive precision required to document site-specific graffiti. To address this, the catalogue incorporates additional fields inspired by domain-specific standards such as the Categories for the Description of Works of Art (CDWA) and VRA Core, both of which emphasise materiality, technique, and spatial context in the documentation of visual culture (CDWA, 2015; VRA Core 4.0, 2024).

The resulting data model adopts an object-oriented structure in which each row represents a single graffiti work and its corresponding photograph, and each column corresponds to a distinct metadata element. Core descriptive fields—such as title, description, subject, and workType—align with Dublin Core’s emphasis on content and contextual information (Gilliland, 2016). Additional fields extend this schema to capture characteristics specific to graffiti as an immovable, urban cultural object, including material, technique, and multiple forms of spatial metadata ([location](#), [location.site](#), [location.creation](#), [location.documentation](#)). This granularity reflects best practices in visual-culture documentation, where distinguishing between the physical work, its environment, and the circumstances of its capture is essential (CDWA, 2015; VRA Core 4.0, 2024).

The catalogue also incorporates structured identifiers to support consistency and long-term interoperability. The workID / imageID field follows a stable naming convention (e.g., GRAFFITI_ViennaTrashBin), enabling reliable cross-referencing between the catalogue and Omeka. Rights information is recorded in a dedicated rights field, which documents the legal and contextual status of the graffiti and its photographic representation—an important consideration in projects involving public, often anonymous artistic production (Watkins & Beaver, 2008). Technical characteristics of the digital files are captured through the image format field (e.g., JPEG), complementing the descriptive metadata.

Because the catalogue uses a hybrid schema—combining Dublin Core with custom fields tailored to graffiti—an accompanying mapping table clarifies how each local field corresponds to Dublin Core elements. For example, agent ([role=artist](#)) maps to Creator, material and technique map to Format within Omeka’s unqualified Dublin Core, and all spatial fields (including [location.creation](#)) map to Coverage. This mapping ensures that the enhanced descriptive richness required to document urban graffiti remains compatible with Omeka’s Dublin Core-based infrastructure and broader metadata exchange practices (Gilliland, 2016; Miller, 2022).

Mapping Table

The mapping table can be found below:

Own Catalogue Field	Dublin Core Element
workID / imageID	Identifier
title	Title
agent (role=artist)	Creator
project source	Source
agent (role=photographer)	Contributor
date.type	Category / Date Captured
date.value	Date
description	Description
Subject	Subject
workType	Type
imageType	Type
material	Format
technique	Format
image format	Format
location	Coverage
location.site	Coverage
location.creation	Coverage
location.documentation	Coverage
rights	Rights
relation (type = collection)	Relation
inscription.language	Language
digitalSurrogate	Identifier (secondary use)

Selection Criteria for Digitising Graffiti in Vienna's 21st and 22nd Districts

- Location accessibility — Graffiti had to be reachable on foot and photographable without trespassing.
- Public visibility — Only graffiti visible from public streets, sidewalks, or transit areas was included.
- Ephemerality — Priority was given to works likely to be removed, painted over, or degraded.
- Variety of surfaces — Items were selected to represent different urban materials (bins, walls, utility boxes, bus stops).
- Range of techniques — Inclusion of tags, throw-ups, stickers, stencils, and small murals to reflect diversity.
- Residential context — Graffiti had to be located within neighbourhoods rather than tourist or commercial zones.
- Photographability — Items were selected based on whether they could be captured without obstructing pedestrians or including identifiable individuals.
- Safety and feasibility — Only locations safe to access at night (when photography was conducted) were included.
- Narrative value — Preference for graffiti that contributed to understanding the everyday cultural landscape of the districts.
- Condition and legibility — Graffiti had to be sufficiently intact to be meaningfully documented.

Records

As required in the assignment, the appendix includes two sample records illustrating the metadata structure used in the collection.

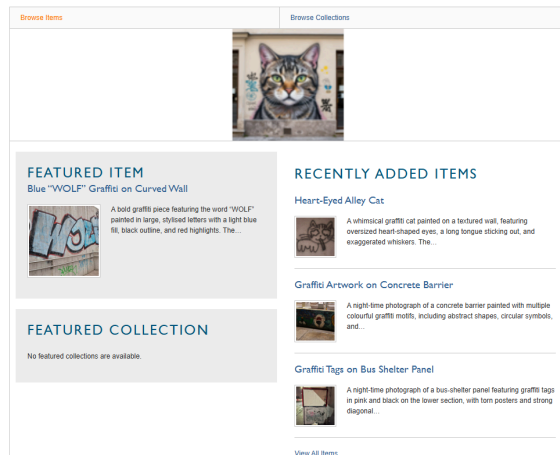
Work ID	Title	Screenshot
GRAFFITI_ViennaSmiley107	Graffiti Smiley and Number Tag on Wall	
GRAFFITI_AstronautGraffiti	Astronaut Mural with Graffiti Overlays in Vienna	

Omeka Screenshots

**Graffiti in
Vienna**



The screenshot above shows the Omeka page's logo, while the second one displays the UI.



References

Caplan, P. (2003). *Metadata fundamentals for all librarians*. American Library Association.

Categories for the Description of Works of Art. (2015). *CDWA Full*. Getty Research Institute. https://www.getty.edu/research/publications/electronic_publications/cdwa/

Dublin Core Metadata Initiative. (2024). *Dublin Core Metadata Element Set, Version 1.1*. <https://www.dublincore.org/specifications/dublin-core/dces/>

Drucker, J. (2021). Digitization & file formats. In *The digital humanities coursebook: An introduction to digital methods for research and scholarship* (pp. 43–51). Routledge.

Gilliland, A. J. (2016). Setting the stage. In M. Baca (Ed.), *Introduction to metadata* (pp. 1–20). Getty Publications.

Miller, S. J. (2022). *Metadata for digital collections* (2nd ed.). Facet Publishing.

Pearce, S. M. (1992). *Museums, objects, and collections: A cultural study*. Smithsonian Institution Press.

Terras, M. (2018). Digitization and digital resources in the humanities. In C. Warwick, M. Terras, & J. Nyhan (Eds.), *Digital humanities in practice* (2nd ed., pp. 47–70). Facet Publishing.

UNESCO. (2003). *Charter on the preservation of digital heritage*. <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/>

VRA Core 4.0. (2024). *VRA Core: A data standard for the description of works of visual culture*. Visual Resources Association. <https://vraweb.org/resources/vra-core/>

Watkins, J., & Beaver, J. (2008). What do we mean by “heritage”? *Heritage Management*, 1(1), 9–36.